

Lesson 18

Explaining a Project Update



Warm-Up

1. What's the most challenging project update you've had to give?
2. How do you handle project updates for complex or technical projects?





Role-Play

Scenario: David, a project manager, needs to give a project update to his team leader, John.

David: Hi, John. I wanted to give you a quick update on the project.

John: Sounds good. What's the latest?

David: *Here's the latest update*, we're currently *on track* to meet the deadline. However, we encountered some issues with the design phase which initially made me worried that we might be *behind schedule* with the project's *deliverables*.

John: What kind of issues?

David: We had some miscommunication with the design team, this *bottleneck* threatened to cause delays in meeting the project's *milestone*. But we've worked it out, and everything is back on track.

John: Okay, good. What's the plan for the next phase?

David: We're going to start testing next week. I'll send you a detailed plan by the end of the day.

Role-Play Analysis

Answer the following questions:

1. According to David, what was the cause of the design phase delays?
2. What can you do to avoid miscommunication with the team?
3. How did John confirm the team's next steps?
4. What is the team's next plan?
5. What do you think will be the impact of delays on the project?



Practice

Activity 1:

Instructions: Fill in the blanks with the correct words using project management vocabulary in context.

Word Options: *on track, behind schedule, milestone, deliverables, bottleneck*

David: We're currently _____ (1) with our project timeline, having completed the first phase ahead of schedule. However, we've encountered a _____ (2) in the development process that caused some delays. Despite this, we're confident that we'll meet our next _____ (3) and deliver all the required _____ (4) to the client. Unfortunately, this means we'll be slightly _____ (5) for the next phase.

Activity 2:

Instructions: Read the statements and decide whether they are true or false. Correct the false statement to make it factual.

1. A project is on track when it meets all its deadlines. (True/False)
2. A bottleneck in a project is a point where progress is accelerated. (True/False)
3. Deliverables are the intermediate steps in a project. (True/False)
4. A milestone is a significant event or achievement in a project. (True/False)
5. A project is behind schedule when it is ahead of its planned timeline. (True/False)



Production

MINI ROLE-PLAY: GIVING UPDATES

***Instructions:** Practice providing a project update in a clear and concise manner in the following scenarios:*

Scenario 1: You're managing a software development project, and you've just completed the coding phase. Explain the project update to your team, including any next steps for the testing phase.

Scenario 2: Your project is facing budget constraints, and you need to adjust the scope to stay within budget. Explain the project update to your team, highlighting the changes that will be made.

Scenario 3: You've completed the first phase of your research project, and the results are promising. Explain the project update to your research partner, discussing the implications of the results and the next steps.

Discussion:

1. What specific language or phrases did you use to communicate important information effectively?
2. Did you encounter any challenges in conveying updates in your scenario? How did you overcome them?
3. How important is it to keep your team or partner informed about project progress?
4. How did you feel about delivering project updates, and what would you improve for future updates?



Key Vocabulary

Word/Phrase	Use	Example
On Track	Used in progressing as planned or in meeting goals and objectives	<i>The project is currently on track to meet its deadline of April 15th.</i>
Behind schedule	Used in a situation where a project, task, or activity is not progressing as planned and is falling behind the expected deadline.	<i>Unfortunately, the project is currently behind schedule due to unforeseen delays in the development phase.</i>
Milestone	Used in a significant event or achievement that marks a major point in a project.	<i>We've reached a major milestone in the project, completing the design phase ahead of schedule.</i>
Deliverables	Used in referring to the specific products or services that are expected to be delivered as part of a project.	<i>The project team has completed the following deliverables: design documents and user feedback analysis.</i>
Bottleneck	Used when the flow of work, resources, or information is restricted or slowed down, causing delays.	<i>We've identified a bottleneck in the testing phase, which is causing delays in the project timeline.</i>
Here's the latest update...	This expression clearly signals that new information will be provided and used to provide a brief and on point update.	<i>Here's the latest update on my task list and the challenges I'm facing.</i>



Homework

To help you feel more confident and prepared when explaining project updates, answer the following questions.

Directions: Write a short professional email to your manager giving a project update. In your email, answer the following questions:

1. What is the status of the project you are involved with?
2. What progress has been made since the last update?
3. Are there any changes to the project timeline or budget?
4. What are the next steps for the project?
5. Are there any issues that need to be addressed?